The Gilded Age: Series Outline

Chunk History · six episodes plus a short Progressive Era mini unit · for lesson planning

Unit compelling question (used in class, never named in the videos):
Who should look out for ordinary people: the rich, the government, or ordinary people themselves?
Each episode quietly adds evidence. Students can keep a three-column chart (the rich / the government / ordinary people) across the series and argue a position at the end.

Ep	Title / topic	Supporting question	Evidence it adds	Status
1	Steel, Oil, and Sugar: industrialization and the tycoons	How did America get so rich, so fast, and who ended up with the money?	The rich build industries; the government stands back	Finished, 13:11
2	The Ball and the Basement: wealth and culture	What did the richest people in America think they owed everyone else?	The rich: Social Darwinism vs the Gospel of Wealth; family support	Finished, about 10:30
3	Immigration	Was America a land of opportunity for newcomers?	Ordinary people: networks, family, mutual aid	Planned
4	Cities and political machines	Did political machines help the poor or exploit them?	The government, machine version	Planned
5	Labor unions	How did workers fight for a bigger share, and what did it cost them?	Ordinary people: unions and strikes	Planned
6	Populism and the politics of the era	Could ordinary Americans use politics to fight back?	Ordinary people through the government	Planned
Mini	The Progressive Era	(the payoff)	The government steps in, pushed by ordinary people	Planned

The Kellys are a composite Irish family in Brooklyn (made up, but true to real lives): Michael (19, sugar refinery worker), his sister Nora (18, live-in maid), Ma, a younger brother. Episodes 3 to 6 are outlines: details will change after research.

Episode 1 · Steel, Oil, and Sugar

Finished · 13:11 | 1870s to 1890s

How did America get so rich, so fast, and who ended up with the money?

CHAPTERS

Time	Chapter	Content
0:00	The Bridge	Brooklyn Bridge opens, May 24, 1883; some of its wire had failed its safety test. Meet Michael Kelly.
1:07	The Name	Mark Twain's "Gilded Age"; gold vs gilt; railroads and time zones (1883).
2:09	The Machines	The Bessemer process (steel), Edison's bulb and power station, electric meters.
3:14	The Refinery	Michael's ten-hour shifts at a Brooklyn sugar refinery; bone char.
4:02	The Weaver's Son	Andrew Carnegie: weaver's son to steel king; vertical integration; his note to quit at 35.
5:54	The Con Man's Son	John D. Rockefeller: rebates, buying rivals, horizontal integration, monopoly, Standard Oil trust.
8:29	The Trust Comes to Brooklyn	The Sugar Trust (1887) reaches Michael's refinery; dinner by a kerosene lamp.
9:22	Leave It Alone	Laissez-faire; Sherman Antitrust Act (1890) and the E.C. Knight case (1895); robber barons or captains of industry?
10:16	Gold or Gilt	How the bridge's bad wire was caught; the answer; "Who got the gold, and who only got the gilt?"

VOCABULARY

Gilded, gilt, industrialization, entrepreneurs, Bessemer process, vertical integration, horizontal integration, rebate, monopoly, trust, laissez-faire, free market, robber barons, captains of industry

EVIDENCE FOR THE COMPELLING QUESTION

- **The rich:** Carnegie and Rockefeller build huge industries and fortunes; prices fall for consumers.
- **The government:** mostly stands back (laissez-faire); the Sherman Act is weakened by E.C. Knight.
- **Ordinary people:** Michael's pay and hours stay the same while the trust takes over.

LESSON HOOKS

- Robber barons vs captains of industry debate (Carnegie, Rockefeller).
- Vertical vs horizontal integration sort (the pizza-shop analogy from the video).
- Primary sources: Puck cartoons of Standard Oil, Carnegie's 1868 memo to himself.

Episode 2 · The Ball and the Basement

Finished · about 10:30 | 1882 to 1889

What did the richest people in America think they owed everyone else?

CHAPTERS

#	Chapter	Content
1	The Ball	The Vanderbilt costume ball, March 26, 1883, 660 Fifth Avenue; Nora carries ices in the kitchen. Cost about $250,000 (about $9 million today).
2	New Money	Old money vs new money; Mrs. Astor and "the 400"; the calling-card story (told as legend).
3	The Party	The hobby-horse quadrille; Alice Vanderbilt as "The Electric Light"; supper at 2 a.m.; the bill.
4	The Basement	A live-in maid's life: hours, one afternoon off, about $3.60 a week (about $130 today). One party = more than 1,300 years of her pay. Her wages help pay the family's rent.
5	Survival of the Fittest	Herbert Spencer and Social Darwinism; his 1882 Delmonico's banquet; William Graham Sumner: the rich owe nothing; A, B, C, D and the "Forgotten Man."
6	Sunday	Workers' Sunday at a Brooklyn ball game (the "Beer and Whiskey League") vs the rich at polo, Newport tennis, yachts.
7	The Gospel of Wealth	Carnegie's "Wealth" (1889): "dies disgraced"; about 1,700 U.S. libraries; the rich as trustees; workers ask for higher pay instead.
8	Rags to Riches	The Horatio Alger story vs the evidence: most business leaders came from comfortable families. The two answers to the question.

VOCABULARY

old money, new money, the 400, calling card, quadrille, domestic servant, live-in, survival of the fittest, Social Darwinism, Gospel of Wealth, philanthropy, trustee, rags to riches

EVIDENCE FOR THE COMPELLING QUESTION

- **The rich:** Sumner says nothing is owed; Carnegie says give it away, but on his own terms (libraries, not wages).
- **The government:** absent from this episode, which is itself a point for discussion.
- **Ordinary people:** Nora's wages on the family table; the family supports itself.

LESSON HOOKS

- Do the math: today's-money conversions; maid-years for the party.
- Sumner vs Carnegie paired reading (short excerpts of *What Social Classes Owe to Each Other* and "Wealth").
- Sumner's A, B, C, D: students guess who C and D are before the reveal.
- Is your town library a Carnegie library? Check the cornerstone.

Episodes 3 to 6 (planned)

Outlines only: dates and details to be checked

EPISODE 3 · IMMIGRATION

Was America a land of opportunity for newcomers?

- Castle Garden, then Ellis Island (1892); "old" vs "new" immigrants.
- Letters home pulling cousins over; the garment trade and sweatshops.
- **Kellys:** a Jewish family from the Russian Empire moves into the Kellys' building; the Irish family's own prejudice toward newer arrivals.
- **Evidence:** ordinary people look out for each other (networks, mutual aid, family).

EPISODE 4 · CITIES AND POLITICAL MACHINES

Did political machines help the poor or exploit them?

- Tenements and Jacob Riis's photographs; Tammany Hall, Boss Tweed, Thomas Nast cartoons; Plunkitt's "honest graft."
- **Kellys:** the younger brother works for the ward boss, who brings coal and a turkey in winter.
- **Evidence:** a "government" that helps, at a price.

EPISODE 5 · LABOR UNIONS

How did workers fight for a bigger share, and what did it cost them?

- Knights of Labor; Haymarket (1886); Homestead (1892, Carnegie's mill: the payoff to Episode 2); Pullman (1894); Gompers and the AFL.
- **Kellys:** Michael joins the Knights of Labor.
- **Evidence:** ordinary people organize; the government often sides with owners.

EPISODE 6 · POPULISM

Could ordinary Americans use politics to fight back?

- Farmers' Alliance; Omaha Platform (1892); Panic of 1893; gold vs silver; Bryan's "Cross of Gold" (1896); why Populism lost, and how its ideas lived on.
- **Kellys:** letters from a relative out west; the family argues over the 1896 vote.
- **Evidence:** ordinary people try to use the government.

Progressive Era mini unit (after the series)
The payoff: the government steps in, pushed by ordinary people. Muckrakers (Riis, Ida Tarbell on Standard Oil, a callback to Episode 1; Upton Sinclair), settlement houses (Jane Addams), trust-busting and the 1911 Standard Oil breakup, meat inspection (1906), the 16th and 17th Amendments (1913). Many reforms trace back to the Populists of Episode 6, so students may conclude "all three, working together."